

“a platform.” Home Assistant’s add-ons page shows the path: Settings → Add-ons → Add-on store, with some add-ons visible only in Advanced Mode.

Saturday afternoon: add-on discipline

1. Settings → Add-ons → Add-on store.
2. Enable Advanced Mode if you need it (Profile).
3. Install only what you need this weekend:
 - Nothing on Saturday (unless you know why)
 - Matter Server on Sunday (Home Assistant installs it when you add Matter on OS)

Why the restraint? Because every extra add-on becomes one more thing to update, secure, and troubleshoot. Add-ons are powerful; use them like spices, not like rice.

5) Install the Companion App (your best “smart home remote”)

Even if you don’t care about controlling devices from your phone (you will), the Home Assistant Companion app gives you:

- Push notifications (useful for door sensors and water leaks)
- Presence detection (home/away)
- A clean mobile UI without opening a browser tab

Also: many Matter-sharing flows rely on the Companion app. Home Assistant’s Matter docs list having the latest Companion app as a prerequisite when sharing devices from another platform into Home Assistant.

Step-by-step

1. Install the Home Assistant Companion app on your phone.
2. Log in to your instance over the local network.
3. Approve permissions you actually want (location for presence, notifications for alerts).

Keep it simple: we’re not doing “track me everywhere” on day one. Just get the app connected.

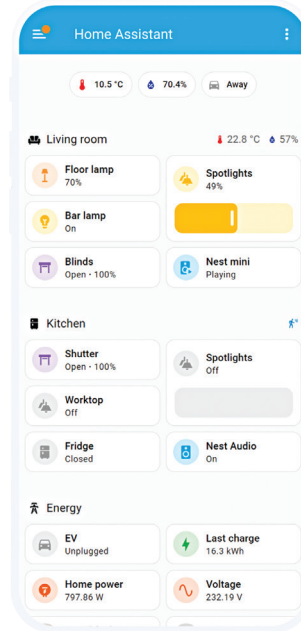
6) Your first dashboard: keep Overview auto, build your own

Home Assistant’s dashboard guide warns that the default Overview dashboard stops auto-updating once you edit it. Their recommended approach is to create a new dashboard first and customize that.

Build a “Daily Driver” dashboard (15–20 minutes)

1. Settings → Dashboards → Add dashboard.
2. Choose Default dashboard, name it “Daily Driver,” pick an icon.
3. Open it → Edit → Take control (accept the warning).
4. Add a few cards only:
 - Lights/switches you use daily

- One climate control (if available)
 - One safety view (door sensor, or a single camera tile)
 - One “Status” section (Wi-Fi/router entity if you have it, plus a battery sensor later)
5. Put the most-used card top-left (Home Assistant’s guide demonstrates editing/moving cards)



Create a second dashboard tab: “Admin”

Put the messy stuff here: device lists, updates, logs. Your family should never need to see it.

Rule: your main dashboard should answer “what’s on, what’s open, what’s wrong” in five seconds.

7) Backups: set them up before you add devices

Home Assistant documents backups under Common Tasks: Settings → System → Backups, including automatic backup configuration and backup locations. Their “3...2...1... Backup” post explains the project’s focus on resilience and mentions cloud backup for Home Assistant Cloud subscribers (with limits).

Saturday evening: do this (non-negotiable)

1. Settings → System → Backups → Create backup.
 2. Download the backup to your laptop.
 3. Store a second copy elsewhere (NAS/external drive/cloud).
 4. Configure Automatic backups and enable at least one extra location.
- Must do backup minimum: weekly automatic backups + one off-device copy.

8) Matter in Home Assistant: the supported path

Home Assistant’s Matter docs are blunt: running the Matter add-on on Home Assistant OS is the recommended and currently supported option; other paths are unsupported / “at your own risk.”

Prerequisites for adding Matter devices

From the Matter docs:

- Latest Home Assistant installed
- Matter integration added via Settings → Devices & services
- The device’s QR code or numeric setup code (without it, re-commissioning after a reset is painful)
- If it’s Matter-over-Thread, you need a Thread border router available (examples include Nest Hub 2nd gen, or Home Assistant with OpenThread Border Router).